

THE WAY

Founding Gathering & 90-Day Pilot Field Guide

A reversible pre-incorporation field test for the Way, the Assembly, and future Houses of Prayer

Version 1.1 | September 21, 2026

Working organization: UNDECIDED

Pilot status

This pilot is a Founding Gathering Circle and experimental religious program. It is not yet a legally recognized House of Prayer, separate legal entity, church determination, statutory membership body, or corporate program unless and until the future corporation lawfully authorizes it.

1. Pilot purpose and success criteria

- Test whether the Way can be practiced in ordinary community life without founder dependency or coercion.
- Test whether prayer, study, fellowship, service, discernment, and the Companion pathway are understandable to real participants.
- Find contradictions between the Constitution, Teaching Baseline, Handbook, integrity controls, and lived practice.
- Measure whether people can question, decline, criticize, and leave without pressure.
- Generate evidence for v1.1/v1.2 revision before the first official House is recognized.

Success is not retention

A pilot does not “succeed” because everyone joins. A healthy result may include participants deciding the Way is not for them and leaving without harm. Retention, donations, and loyalty are not primary success metrics.

2. Pre-launch gates

Gate	State	Pilot rule
Adult-only public pilot	YES	Default until child-program safeguards are fully active.

Gate	State	Pilot rule
Public description explains experimental/pre-incorporation status	REQUIRED	Avoid misrepresentation.
Participant Rights / Companion Handbook available	REQUIRED	People must know rights before belonging decisions.
Complaint route	REQUIRED	At least one normal contact and one independent/outside route; if only founder exists, use an external trusted professional/volunteer route rather than self-review.
Emergency plan	REQUIRED	Venue exits, emergency services, incident contact.
Safeguarding plan for any minors present incidentally	REQUIRED	No children's ministry or unsupervised child programming during pilot.
Money handling	LIMITED	Avoid public charitable fundraising until entity/controls/status are clarified. Shared-cost arrangements must be transparent.
Founder disclosure	REQUIRED	Founder identifies personal role and states pilot participants are not entering a legal contract or surrendering conscience.

3. Pilot cohort and invitation language

Recommended first cohort: 6-20 adults. A smaller cohort is acceptable. Do not manufacture scale before the model is healthy.

Suggested invitation language

“We are testing a new religious community framework called the Way. The pilot combines prayer, study, fellowship, service, and disciplined inquiry. Major theological questions remain open. Participation does not make you a member, donor, employee, or Companion, and you may stop at any time. The founder is not treated as infallible, and critical feedback is specifically requested.”

4. 90-day sequence

Stage	Timing	Required work
0 / Setup	Before first gathering	Publish pilot status; venue/emergency plan; distribute rights; activate complaint route; prepare feedback instruments; confirm no child-program launch.

Stage	Timing	Required work
1-2	Orientation	Introduce the Way, Companion/Assembly/House vocabulary, participant rights, teaching-status system, and why open questions remain open.
3-4	Prayer + Study	Pilot simple Prayer and Study gatherings; explicitly label historical facts, interpretations, and open theology.
5-6	Fellowship + Service	Pilot Common Table/fellowship and one service activity with no conversion requirement.
7-8	Discernment + disagreement	Run a real nontrivial discernment question; ensure dissent and minority notes are preserved.
9-10	Companion pathway	Offer voluntary Companion orientation. No countdown, altar-call pressure, or required public declaration.
11	Founder-exit exercise	Founder deliberately steps out of facilitation for a full gathering; another facilitator runs the process from written materials.
12	Evaluation / closure decision	Conduct 90-day review; decide whether to revise, pause, continue Gathering Circle status, or after incorporation seek House-in-Formation recognition.

5. Recommended recurring rhythm

Frequency	Practice	Purpose
Weekly	One 60-90 minute gathering	Rotate Prayer / Study / Fellowship / Discernment; service can be monthly.
Monthly	Service + Common Table	Practical outward service followed by optional shared meal/fellowship.
Every 30 days	Pilot health review	Review power concentration, complaints, departures, teaching clarity, finances/costs, accessibility, and founder dependency.
Day 90	Formal field review	Publish summary to participants; list changes; do not hide negative feedback.

6. Standard gathering order

1. Welcome and status reminder: attendance is voluntary; participants may step out or leave at any time.
2. Brief silence/attention.

3. Prayer, reading, or source witness appropriate to the gathering.
4. Context: identify whether material is primary witness, historical reconstruction, interpretation, teaching, or open question.
5. Discussion / shared reflection with explicit permission to disagree or pass.
6. Announcements limited to actual logistics; no pressure donation or loyalty appeal.
7. Closing prayer/reflection or clear ending.
8. Optional fellowship afterward.

7. Pilot measurement dashboard

Measure	Question	Evidence
Conscience clarity	Can participants explain that they may disagree/decline/leave?	Anonymous pulse; target $\geq 90\%$ understand.
Founder dependency	Can a gathering function without founder facilitation?	Founder-exit exercise; record failures.
Epistemic clarity	Can participants distinguish evidence, interpretation, teaching, and open question?	Short scenario test / discussion.
Complaint accessibility	Can participants identify an independent concern route?	Anonymous pulse; target $\geq 90\%$ understand.
Pressure / coercion	Any reports of pressure around joining, money, disclosure, relationships, fasting, prayer, or deference?	Zero tolerance for systemic pattern; investigate every report.
Exit quality	Did anyone leave/decline and experience pressure or relationship punishment?	Follow-up only if freely consented; no pursuit.
Teaching correction	Were factual/theological errors corrected publicly?	Correction log.
Service integrity	Was aid/service conditioned on religious participation?	Must be no.
Safeguarding	Any child/vulnerable-person concerns handled under external/legal-first rules?	Incident log and required reports.
Operational burden	Can the model run with available time/costs without secret unpaid dependency?	Monthly cost/time log.

8. Red-flag stop conditions

- A participant reports threats, retaliation, stalking, coercive sexual conduct, violence, safeguarding concerns, or significant fraud.
- Founder or facilitator resists independent review or treats criticism as spiritual betrayal.
- Participants are pressured to cut off family, critics, other religions, clinicians, attorneys, or outside information.

- Group repeatedly presents open theology as certain because the founder prefers it.
- Money is solicited through promises of spiritual status, protection, healing, revelation, access, or fear.
- Children's programming begins without the safeguarding system actually being ready.
- A participant's housing, employment, healthcare, intimate relationship, education, or legal choices are manipulated through spiritual authority.
- The pilot begins presenting itself as an incorporated nonprofit, recognized 501(c)(3), or official House when that status does not yet exist.

Stop means stop

A stop condition triggers safety/legal action as appropriate, fact preservation, and suspension of the affected activity. "Protecting the project" is not a reason to continue.

9. 30/60/90-day review forms

30-day review

- ☐ What feels healthy? _____
- ☐ Where did pressure or ambiguity appear? _____
- ☐ Can participants describe their rights? _____
- ☐ What teaching was confusing or overstated? _____
- ☐ What must change before day 60? _____

60-day review

- ☐ Can non-founder facilitators operate the gathering?

- ☐ Are complaints and disagreement handled calmly?

- ☐ Are practices spiritually meaningful without emotional manipulation?

- ☐ What costs/time burdens are emerging? _____
- ☐ Should Companion orientation continue, change, or pause?

90-day review

- ☐ Would we trust this system with a stranger who knows no founder?

- ☐ Can a person leave safely? _____
- ☐ What constitutional language failed in practice? _____
- ☐ What must be revised before an official House-in-Formation?

- ☐ Continue, revise, pause, or close the pilot? _____

10. Pilot participant acknowledgement

I understand that this is a voluntary experimental religious-community pilot. I am not required to become a Companion, donate, disclose private information, accept the founder's interpretation, or continue attending. I may criticize the pilot or leave without permission. I understand that the pilot is not representing itself as a separate legal entity, recognized House of Prayer, or IRS-recognized charity unless that status is later lawfully established.

Participant name (optional for anonymous participation)	_____
Signature (if used)	_____
Date	_____

11. 90-day final decision record

Decision	☐ Continue Gathering Circle ☐ Revise and repeat pilot ☐ Pause ☐ Close ☐ After incorporation, seek House-in-Formation recognition
Evidence reviewed	Attendance pattern; anonymous feedback; complaints; departure experiences; founder-exit exercise; correction log; safeguarding; costs; service outcomes.
Required revisions	[[LIST]]
Unresolved risks	[[LIST]]
Next review date	[[DATE]]